

STAGE FIVE • THINKING, REASONING & MENTAL MODELS

FIRSTS

ICEBREAKERS / OPENERS

Short, stage-themed warm-ups tied to what each session actually covers

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Icebreakers / Openers

Stage Five • Thinking, Reasoning & Mental Models

PURPOSE

Stage Five's four sessions — Foundational Mental Models, Applied Reasoning & Reflection, Advanced Frameworks I, and Advanced Frameworks II — each get one icebreaker built directly from that session's actual content.

Because this stage is more abstract than most, these openers lean specifically on producing a felt, personal experience of the underlying idea before any formal teaching: a riddle that tricks your instinct, a bias caught in the room in real time, a failure-mode brainstorm that turns out easier than expected, a mistake pattern everyone recognizes in themselves. The goal is to make an abstract reasoning concept concrete and memorable in under ten minutes.

Each includes the instructions to read to the group, a time estimate, and a short note on why it's specifically the right opener for what comes next.

Four Openers, One Per Session

SESSION 1

The Instinct Trap

TIME: 10 min

1. Pose a classic, deceptively simple riddle to the group (e.g., “a bat and ball cost \$1.10 total, the bat costs \$1 more than the ball, how much is the ball?”). Give everyone 30 seconds to answer silently.
2. Ask for a show of hands on who answered \$0.10 (the common, wrong, instinctive answer) versus \$0.05 (correct).
3. Reveal the correct answer and briefly discuss: what made the wrong answer feel so immediately right?

WHY THIS WORKS

This produces a genuine, memorable experience of instinctive reasoning failing, before any formal teaching — exactly the gap Mental Model Awareness (G1) is about to name and address.

SESSION 2

Spot Your Own Bias

TIME: 8 min

1. Show the group a short, ambiguous scenario (facilitator-prepared: e.g., a manager who didn't respond to an email — rude, busy, or didn't see it?).
2. Ask everyone to silently write down their first, instinctive explanation.
3. Reveal that all three explanations are equally plausible, and ask: what does your first instinct say about which kind of story you default to telling?

WHY THIS WORKS

A fast, personal preview of the Cognitive Bias Audit (G9) that comes early in this session — it makes bias feel like something genuinely observable in the room, not just an abstract concept.

SESSION 3

The Failure Brainstorm

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask the group to imagine a hypothetical group project has failed spectacularly. In pairs, brainstorm as many ways it could have failed as possible in 3 minutes.
2. Collect a few examples and note how quickly and easily people generated a long list.
3. Ask: was that easier or harder than trying to list everything that would guarantee success?

WHY THIS WORKS

This is a direct, hands-on preview of Inversion Thinking (H18) later in this session, making the

core insight, that failure modes are often easier to spot than success conditions, personally felt rather than just described.

SESSION 4

The Checklist Confession

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask: “what's a mistake you've made more than once doing something you've genuinely done many times before?”
2. Quick round-robin, one sentence each.
3. Note the pattern out loud: repeated mistakes on familiar tasks are exactly what a checklist is built to catch.

WHY THIS WORKS

Makes Checklists & SOPs Creation (H24), the session's opening FIRST, feel immediately personally relevant rather than a dry administrative exercise.